



Rescue workers search through the rubble after powerful earthquakes in Caracas, Venezuela on Wednesday. AP MORE REPORTS, PAGE 14

Thousands feared killed as twin quakes rock Venezuela, many trapped under rubble

Official toll 188 so far, USGS says may cross 10,000

Vivian Sequera, Mayela Armas & Deisy Buitrago
La Guaira, Caracas, June 25

THOUSANDS OF Venezuelans were feared dead on Thursday after two powerful earthquakes, including the country's

strongest in over a century, wreaked havoc in and around the capital Caracas, trapping people beneath the rubble of collapsed buildings and setting off powerful aftershocks.

A magnitude 7.2 earthquake hit about 160 km west of Caracas on Wednesday evening, followed less than a minute later by a magnitude 7.5 tremor, according to the US Geological Survey (USGS).

The disaster struck a country already grappling with

EXPLAINED **PAGE 12**
BEHIND EARTHQUAKE DEVASTATION: RARE 'SEISMIC DOUBLET', VULNERABLE LOCATION

years of economic turmoil that had left much of its infrastructure fragile, complicating rescue and recovery efforts. In some areas, emergency workers scrambled over the debris of collapsed buildings

through the evening and into Thursday. In others, residents decried a lack of help.

Jorge Rodriguez, who heads Venezuela's national assembly and is the brother of interim President Delcy Rodriguez, said at least 188 people were confirmed dead and 200 were trapped. He said 1,520 people were injured and at least 250 buildings had been damaged or destroyed.

The worst-affected area, »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 26~06~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"A VOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or

indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing

of other topics in the main exam.

Govt expands QR code-tracking to curb fake cancer drugs, vaccines

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, June 25

IN A move to check the circulation of counterfeit medicines, the Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare has expanded the ambit of the 'QR code-based track-and-trace framework' to include all vaccines, antimicrobials, anti-cancer medicines and narcotic and psychotropic drugs.

The ministry has notified amendments to the Drugs Rules, 1945, bringing these categories of medicines under

Schedule H2, which mandates the use of bar codes or Quick Response (QR) codes for product identification and verification.

This means manufacturers of all such medicines must affix a QR code either on the primary packaging, or on the secondary packaging in case of space constraints, that can identify each individual unit — thereby helping regulators trace its journey from the manufacturing unit to the market.

"The enhanced traceability mechanism will facilitate authentication of medicines at vari-

ous stages of the supply chain and enable improved tracking and verification of drug products. The measure is expected to strengthen regulatory oversight and support efforts to curb the distribution of spurious medicines in the market. It will also contribute to the national fight against Anti-Microbial Resistance (AMR) by enabling better identification and monitoring of counterfeit and substandard antimicrobial products," the ministry said in a statement on Thursday.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• AMONG MEASURES PROPOSED WERE AN SOS PHONE NUMBER, GPS AMBULANCES, GOOD SAMARITAN LAW AND A TRAUMA REGISTRY

Saving lives on road: SC told states to put in 5 key measures, hardly any state did

PAGE 1
anchor

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, June 25

INDIA'S DISMAL road safety record of 1.77 lakh fatalities a year has a revealing backstory. Not a single state has a complete trauma care architecture the Supreme Court sought for saving lives, according to data submitted to it by 34 states and Union Territories over the last nine months.

A common emergency phone number, GPS-equipped ambulances, a Good Samaritan law, a trauma registry and a res-

• TWO-THIRDS OF DEATHS IN 8 STATES ALONE

State	Road Deaths (2024)	112 NERS Integration	Good Samaritan Grievance	Trauma Registry	Ambulance: Public GPS Dashboard
Uttar Pradesh	24,118	Partial	No	No	Yes
Tamil Nadu	18,449	Partial	NA	Yes	Yes
Maharashtra	15,715	Partial	Yes	Yes	No
Madhya Pradesh	14,791	Partial	No	Yes	No
Karnataka	12,390	NA	Yes	No	No
Rajasthan	11,790	Partial	No	No	No
Bihar	9,347	Partial	No	No	No
Andhra Pradesh	8,346	No	NA	No	No

cue protocol — these are the five most important measures of the total nine the Supreme Court

had asked states to put in place in its May 26 order.

These five measures form a

crucial framework to prepare for the "Golden Hour" — the first 60 minutes after an accident critical

to saving lives.

The top court's order came in a petition filed by SaveLIFE Foundation, a Delhi-based road safety organisation, which had recommended a uniform trauma care system across states.

A comprehensive reading of the 1,200 pages of court submissions shows that of the eight states — Uttar Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Bihar and Andhra Pradesh — that account for two out of every three accident deaths in the country, seven are yet to merge all their emergency numbers into 112; one

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 8

Why states are dragging their feet in establishing a trauma system

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, June 25

POOR COORDINATION among agencies, multiplicity of departments and missing standard operating procedures (SOPs) are some of the key reasons why states have not built a trauma response system as directed by the Supreme Court.

A road fatality involves at least six departments viz., po-

lice, health, road agency, district magistrate office, insurance company and the death registration office, which makes a quick response in emergency cases difficult.

The first challenge whenever an accident happens is which number to call. There are many emergency numbers — police (100), fire (101), medical (102), ambulance (108), highway (1033), women (181),

cyber crime (1930), etc. A single number 112 has been conceived, but this will work only when there is a command centre at the district or state level to deploy required resources from all concerned agencies promptly during an accident.

"The integration to 112 is not just an integration of two computers. It is an integration of two different ecosystems. Currently, the API level integration »CONTINUED ON PAGE 8

Venezuela

La Guaira state, near Caracas, "has become a disaster zone," President Rodriguez said, adding that her government was working with businesses to deploy heavy machinery to accelerate rescue efforts.

"He's under the slabs and there's no machinery to get him out," said La Guaira resident Yamileth Jimenez, whose 19-year-old son is believed trapped in the rubble of their seven-story apartment building. "My father died three days ago and now this happens. It's just my son and me," said Jimenez.

Rescue workers were scarce in the state's coastal capital, also called La Guaira, where volunteers were digging with their bare hands. "We lost everything. We have no food or medicines. We managed to get out in time and only have minor injuries... we hope help arrives quickly," said Pedro Perez, 64, the owner of an upholstery workshop. He said he lost his home and business and had been forced out onto the streets with his wife and children.

Others in La Guaira searched for food and water. Reuters witnessed looting at two stores there. Caracas's main airport in La Guaira was closed on Thursday after suffering damage. Wit-

nesses' footage during the earthquakes showed scenes of panic as ceilings came down.

Residents rush into the streets

Many Venezuelans were at home when the quakes struck during a public holiday. Residents fled shaking buildings and poured into the streets as structures collapsed across Caracas and nearby coastal areas.

"When we went downstairs, the scene was like a horror movie," said Caracas resident Maria Alejandra. "We had to climb over the rubble and everything. The building superintendent with the baby and all the neighbors coming down. But from that building, I only saw that one family got out."

Houses collapsed near the quake's epicenter in Morón, a small seaside town in the state of Carabobo, where there was no water or electricity. Three children were among at least eight killed in the area, municipal Mayor Emily Riera told Reuters.

Website shows over 35,000 people unaccounted for

The US Geological Survey, using predictive modeling to estimate the death toll, said it would most likely run into the thousands, with a substantial

probability of exceeding 10,000.

A website set up to track missing people and shared by leaders from the country's Opposition, many of whom are outside Venezuela, listed more than 35,000 people as unaccounted for just after 1:30 pm local time. Reuters could not verify the veracity of every report.

The 7.5 magnitude quake was Venezuela's strongest since 1900. The country lies on the boundary between the Caribbean and South American plates and has suffered devastating earthquakes, including one that killed an estimated 30,000 people in 1812.

Maria Romero, an 80-year-old pensioner in southern Caracas, said police helped her out of her home. "This earthquake was horrible, even worse than the one in 1967," she said, referring to a magnitude 6.3 quake that the USGS said killed 240 people.

*International
solidarity*

Leaders from across the political spectrum expressed solidarity with Venezuela, a notable shift from the international polarization that has surrounded the country in recent years. Rodriguez said international rescue teams were expected soon and thanked

leaders including US President Donald Trump and Russian President Vladimir Putin.

Expatriate groups representing Venezuela's diaspora, which numbers in the millions after years of mass migration, began organizing aid collections abroad as relatives worked to contact family members back home. Rodríguez called for unity in Venezuela, where anti-government protests over annual inflation of more than 500% have become more frequent since Trump ordered the capture of President Nicolás Maduro in a violent raid in January.

Trump said the US was "ready, willing and able to help" and that the US would "be there for our new and great friends," while US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said rescue teams were being deployed and the Pentagon would send assets to Caracas's badly damaged airport.

UN aid chief Tom Fletcher said the organization was coordinating the rapid deployment of international rescue teams, adding that "a massive collective effort" would be needed in a country where even before the quake, 8 million people needed

humanitarian aid. The UN's Venezuela human rights mission urged the government to lift restrictions on some social media, saying it was a "matter of life and death". Access became available in some areas of the country, where cell services are unreliable. **REUTERS**

QR code-tracking to curb fake cancer drugs

In April this year, an investigation by *The Indian Express*, in association with The International Consortium of Investigative Journalists (ICIJ), had revealed a multi-city counterfeit racket in Keytruda, an expensive cancer drug, in which empty vials were being refilled with anti-fungal medication and resold cheaper.

Usually, drug packages carry only a batch number, which can be easily copied by counterfeiters.

According to the ministry, the QR code will contain key product information such as a unique product identification code, generic and brand names, manufacturer's name and address, batch number, manufacturing and expiry dates, manufacturing licence number, and details of exporters, wherever applicable. Specialised track-and-trace platforms will be able to access this information, to trace the journey of each unit to the market.

According to a gazette notification dated June 22, the change in packaging will be implemented over the next two years — by July 2027 for vaccines, narcotics and anticancer drugs, and by July 2028 for antimicrobials.

Currently, the QR code-based identification is applicable to the top 300 pharmaceutical brands in the country. "With each unit of the drug carrying a unique code, counterfeiting will become difficult. Of course, sometimes counterfeiters may use the

same packaging to beat the system. But even then, it would only work if the fake product is purchased and logged into the system before the genuine product. This is a good move towards ensuring that only genuine products enter the market," said an industry expert.

“Importantly, the government has given enough time for implementing the changes, so companies should be able to exhaust the current stock before the new packaging becomes mandatory,” said the expert.

The matter was first discussed at a meeting of the Drug Technical Advisory Board (DTAB) in August 2024. “The Board was apprised that in New Delhi... unscrupulous criminals, in collusion with hospital pharmacies, were found refilling empty vials of expensive anti-cancer medicines with counterfeit drugs. These fake drugs were then mixed with genuine stocks and sold to unsuspecting cancer patients, putting their life at risk,” said the minutes of the meeting.

“These anti-cancer drugs must be issued under strict directives to implement mandatory QR codes and rigorous track-and-trace mechanisms on every vial and strip of medication that are marketed in India... DTAB deliberated the matter and agreed for the proposed amendment to include all anti-cancer medicines under Schedule H2,” the minutes said.

WEEK AFTER AIIMS OKAYED THE TERMINATION, FLAGGED THAT ‘CONTINUATION OF PREGNANCY CAN HAVE ADVERSE IMPACT’

Delhi High Court allows sexual assault survivor to terminate 28-week pregnancy

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, June 25

THE DELHI High Court on Wednesday allowed a sexual assault survivor, who is a minor, to medically terminate her 28-week pregnancy, observing that such a permission — that goes beyond the 24-week timeline prescribed by law — can be granted in view of grave mental injury and trauma inflicted upon the girl.

This comes less than a week after All India Institute of Medical Science (AIIMS) okayed the termination in a report dated June 19, stating that its continuation was likely to have an "adverse impact" on the minor.

"...although the Medical Termination of Pregnancy Act (MTP Act) does not provide for termination of pregnancy over the gestational age 24 weeks, the extraordinary jurisdiction of the constitutional courts can be invoked for termination of pregnancy in cases of rape, as in such cases, grave mental injury and trauma is inflicted upon the mind of the minor," Justice Mini Pushkarna said in her order.

"The Medical Board of AIIMS, New Delhi, conducted a thorough clinical assessment of the petitioner, including obstetric ultrasound, psychiatric and psychological evaluation. After the clinical assessment, the

Justice Pushkarna directed authorities to offer medical support and assistance to the victim in case the child is born alive.

Medical Board of AIIMS, New Delhi, has clearly given its opinion that the termination of pregnancy can be allowed as continuation of the pregnancy is likely to have an adverse psychological impact on the minor petitioner," she added.

In its medical report, AIIMS

had concluded that the petitioner was medically fit to undergo the procedure for medical termination of pregnancy and that continuing the pregnancy would likely have an adverse psychological impact on the minor.

The Delhi government said that it had no objection if the termination was carried out in this case.

"The petitioner is permitted to get herself admitted at AIIMS, New Delhi, on the strength of the present order for medical termination of her pregnancy. Let the procedure for termination of pregnancy be carried out by a team of competent doctors (as per law)," the

court added.

Justice Pushkarna directed authorities to offer medical support and assistance to the victim in case the child is born alive.

"In case the child is born alive, the Medical Superintendent, AIIMS, New Delhi, in conjunction with the State Authorities would ensure that medical support, as well as every possible and feasible assistance is offered to such child, and the child shall be kept in an incubator...in that case, as per the wish of the minor and her father, such child be given in adoption as per the prescribed procedure," she said in her order.

The court also directed

AIIMS Delhi to preserve the foetus tissue for DNA testing, which would be required in the criminal case against the accused.

The court also further stated that the Delhi government would bear the expenses of the pregnancy.

"Needless to say, respondent no. 2, i.e., Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi (GNCTD) shall bear all the expenses necessary for the termination of the pregnancy of the minor in question and her stay at the hospital during such period. The expenditure towards the post-operative period shall also be borne by the State," it said.

EXPRESS exclusive

Predictive analytics dashboards, hotspot detection: AI-based system set to make AQI forecast sharper

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, June 25

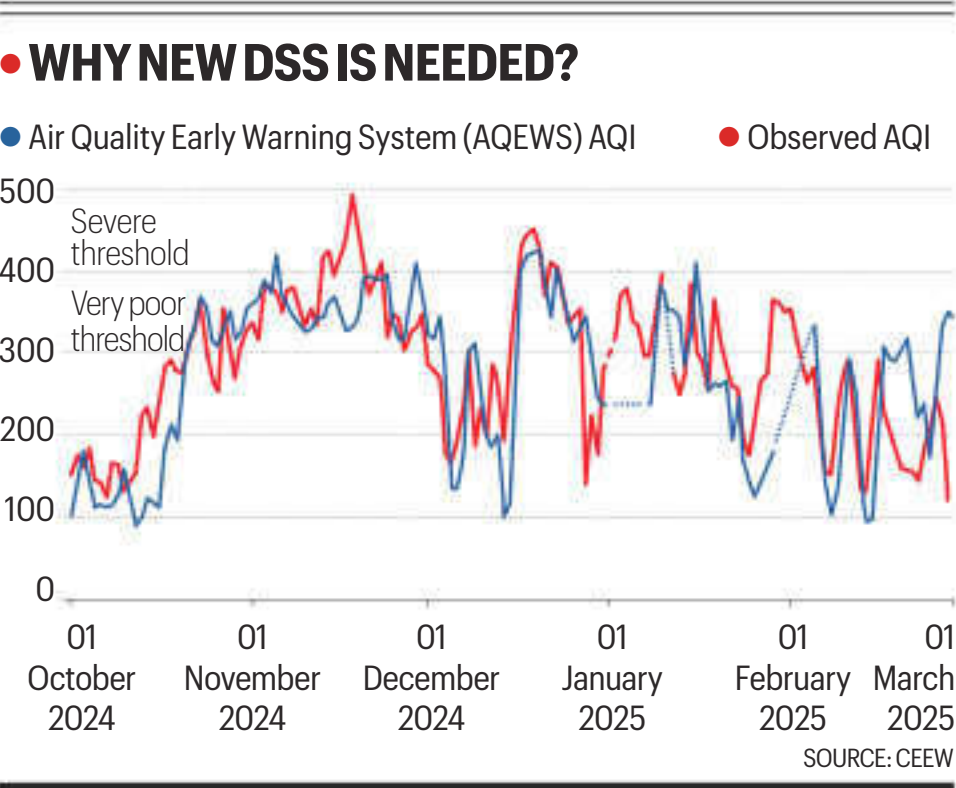
EVERY YEAR, as the Capital battles severe air pollution during winters, emergency measures are introduced based on forecasts of how foul the air is likely to get. With an aim to make those forecasts sharper, IIT-Kanpur's Airawat Research Foundation (ARF) has been building a system under a pilot initiative, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The Indian Express had reported last November that the Decision Support System (DSS) — the current model used for identifying sources and air quality forecasts — suffers from several issues, including an ageing emissions database and accuracy that tails off outside the peak winter months. To resolve these issues and modernise the system, IIT-K signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the Delhi Environment department last month.

Improved prediction

Drawing on a constant stream of live pollution data, the new AI-based DSS will use artificial intelligence (AI) to spot the first signs of a worsening episode early, so that action can be taken before conditions worsen, sources said. This marks a shift from the system that the Capital currently relies on, which produces a single forecast each day from a fixed scientific model. The new system, by contrast, continuously learns from patterns — studying the city's AQI data from the past to anticipate how it will behave next, and improving its predictions in the long run, sources added.

A report by the Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) released last October underlined that even as Delhi's existing forecasting and decision-support setup meets most of the requirements of an ideal system, "Delhi's Air



Quality Early Warning System (AQEWS) and DSS satisfy most of the requirements for an ideal Air Quality Decision Support System (AQDSS)" yet its accuracy is uneven. The forecasts are strongest at the dangerous end of the scale, predicting "very poor and above" (AQI > 300) pollution episodes more than ~80% of the time" in recent winters, but the system has been formally evaluated only for the post-monsoon and winter months, leaving much of the year less rigorously tested.

The DSS has also historically been run mainly during the winter season rather than throughout the year.

A central weakness flagged by the report is the data underpinning the model. CEEW recommends that the emission inventory (EI) — the database of which sources emit how much, on which the forecasts rest — be refreshed on a regular cycle, suggesting "a framework in place to update the EI every two to three years" and noting that "the immediate focus should be on upgrading the EI for the Delhi NCR region to improve Delhi's forecasts."

Even with better data, the report cautions that "even after revamping the EI, the model output may still have errors. It specifically urged the use of ar-

tificial intelligence to close that gap, recommending that the agencies "use machine learning (ML) models to correct errors in the forecasts."

Focus of new system

The AI-driven approach now being piloted by IIT-Kanpur's Airawat Research Foundation maps closely onto these prescriptions — modernising the underlying data, adding machine-learning-based correction, and moving towards a year-round, more granular system. The predictive analytics dashboards, hotspot detection systems, hyperlocal source apportionment and forecasting models that form the core of the new platform are designed to give a far more granular picture of the city's air than they have had before.

According to the agreement, the system is being built to generate pollution forecasts and advisories 48 to 72 hours in advance — a window intended to give authorities time to act before an episode peaks. Rather than a single city-wide snapshot, the tools aim to pinpoint where pollution is building up, identify the airsheds and regional movement feeding it, and trace the contribution of individual sources.

Airawat Research Foundation (ARF) is a non-profit set up

under Section 8 at IIT-Kanpur as part of the Centre's initiative for an AI Centre of Excellence for Sustainable Cities. Beyond forecasting, the MoU envisages expanding Delhi's monitoring network through low-cost sensors, mobile laboratories and the integration of satellite data.

The improved forecasts are meant to affect directly the staged curbs Delhi imposes as air quality deteriorates. Under the plan, the partnership will help formulate Standard Operating Procedures, coordination mechanisms and graded response protocols aligned with the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) and the National Clean Air Programme (NCAP). Because these measures are triggered by forecasts, the accuracy and timing of predictions directly shape how effective -- and how disruptive -- the response is.

As per the arrangement the Department of Environment will coordinate with other departments and stakeholders, provide access to operational and technical data subject to applicable laws, nominate a nodal officer, and validate the analytical models before they are deployed. ARF, for its part, will develop the AI-driven tools, deploy technical experts and researchers, ensure compliance with data protection and IT laws, and submit periodic progress reports and policy recommendations.

A component of the project is devoted to capacity building for training officials to interpret the analytical systems and plan interventions.

The Secretary, Department of Environment, will act as the supervising authority on behalf of the GNCTD, while the CEO or Project Director of airawat will coordinate implementation from the foundation's side, with regular review meetings to track progress. The agreement is valid for five years and can be extended by mutual consent, the MOU has stated.

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, June 25



vilians, as well as violent protests and stone-pelting.

vilians, as well as violent protests and stone-pelting.

The security picture changed again after the 2019 decisions on Article 370 and the state's constitutional status. The 2020-2025 period saw the emergence of hybrid terrorists who specifically targeted Kashmiri Pandits and migrant workers.

Dixit began his career as the SP of Vizag district in Andhra Pradesh but soon joined the IB. As an IB officer, he worked in Kohima, Patna and Hyderabad before being stationed in the headquarters and then sent to Kashmir.

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 25

The Congress leader further criticised new disclosure requirements mandating NGOs to furnish details of their social media accounts, websites and publications, calling them part of a “mass surveillance” framework. Venugopal also linked the rules to the proposed Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which sought to create a “Designated Authority” to take over assets created from foreign contributions when an organisation’s FCRA registration is cancelled, surrendered or expires. The government had deferred discussion on the Bill after Opposition protests in Parliament.

“Now, the government is attempting to implement the same draconian controls through the back door via executive rule amendments, completely bypassing the Lok Sabha,” he said.

Separately, CPI(M) Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas wrote to Home Minister Amit Shah raising what he termed "serious constitutional concerns" over the amendments and seeking their immediate withdrawal. Brittas argued that while regulation of foreign contributions is a legitimate sovereign function, it must not become a tool for constricting the functioning of charitable, educational and faith-based organisations.

In his letter, Brittas said the amendments marked a shift from regulating foreign funds to regulating voluntary organisations themselves, citing provisions that prescribe specific categories of activities, geographically restrict operations, expand reporting requirements and widen the definition of “key functionaries”.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

SC told states to put in 5 key measures, hardly any state did

state Karnataka did not provide information.

The phone number 112 was launched by the Union Home Ministry in 2019 as a Nationwide Emergency Response System that would subsume all emergency numbers for police, fire, medical, ambulance, highways, women, etc. With so many numbers for different

emergencies, NERS was conceived to do away with the confusion about which number to call.

Another important aspect which holds back people from offering help on the road is the fear of being harassed by the police or hospital with a lot of questioning. But of the eight states which accounted for two-thirds of 1.77 lakh fatal-

ities in 2024, only two — Maharashtra and Karnataka — have a grievance redressal system for good samaritans. Four states do not have it, and two states did not provide the required information in the submission to the Supreme Court.

More than 10 years ago, on March 30, 2016, the Supreme Court passed a significant order recognising the rights of Good

Samaritans or bystanders or Rah-Ver. Later, the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTHs) notified the Good Samaritan Rules in 2020 under Section 134A of the Motor Vehicles (Amendment) Act, 2019 to provide protection to people helping out accident victims. Under the scheme, anyone who helps an accident victim receive medical attention within

the Golden Hour is eligible for a Rs 25,000 reward.

However, even 10 years after the court order, the states are dragging their feet on building key trauma-response infrastructure to save lives lost on the country's road network. This matters because at least 30% of all trauma-related deaths in the country are attributable to delays in emerg-

ency care, according to a 2021 NITI Aayog-AIIMS Emergency and Injury Care Report.

The documents further show that states with high fatality also lag behind in building trauma registry, and many are still working on the basis of manual databases. A trauma registry is a clinical database that tracks a patient's journey from the scene of an injury through ambulance, hospital treatment and discharge. It is a key requirement to audit medical care, monitor outcomes, and policy decisions. But five out of these eight states do not have a trauma registry. Three states Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra and Madhya Pradesh said they have a trauma registry system. Tamil Nadu's trauma care registry records pre-hospital ambulance details, transit case details in hospital reception and resuscitation details outcome of patient on a real time basis.

Seven of these eight states meet the criteria for having established a protocol for rescuing victims from the incident site. However, Karnataka does not have a rescue protocol for medical and non-medical rescue and transfer of road crash victims from the site to the hospital.

Overall, of all 34 states and UTs, only eight have a grievance system for Good Samaritans, 17 have a rescue protocol for road victims. As many as 22 states do not have a trauma registry and 13 states either have no GPS or GPS in few ambulances, that too in government ones only.

The Supreme Court, through a letter issued by the Attorney General of India R. Venkataramani on September 2, 2025, asked all states to submit information on whether all registered ambulances, including private ones, were

equipped with GPS. Although eight high-fatality states responded “Yes,” the data provided does not cover private ones, which make it partial information.

On the question of whether the dashboard to track these ambulances have been made public, six states said that though they have a dashboard, it has not been made public. Under such circumstances, for a road accident victim's family, it is difficult to verify whether the nearest ambulance was actually dispatched. Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu said they have made ambulance tracking dashboard open for the public.

Apart from this, seven of the eight states do not track ambulance movements real-time by integrating it with the 112 NERS system. Due to this, it is difficult to rightly calculate the time taken by the ambulance to take the victim to a hospital.

Trauma centre: Why states dragging their feet

of 1033 (highway helpline number) has been done in around 20 states. So when a call related to the national highway is received on 112, it issues a ticket on our system with the location of the accident. For instance, we get around 40 tickets from Uttar Pradesh daily. However, the integration of resources like ambulances etc. and automatic deployment through the system will take time. Recently, we migrated to a software solution developed by C-DAC, which also runs the 112 national emergency response system. So now the integration will be done much faster," said a senior official of Indian Highways Management Company Limited (IHMC), which runs 1033 highway helpline number.

According to the data submitted in the Supreme Court, five states/UTs — Delhi, Kerala, Gujarat, Haryana and Lakshadweep — have reported complete integration to 112 NERS. In its June 22 Budget, the West Bengal government announced the Dial 112 helpline with an allocation of Rs 100 crore. One dedicated vehicle will be placed in each thana for quick response during the emergency.

Apart from this, UP is close to achieving full API level integration, with only 102 emergency medical services remaining to be integrated. UP is also among few states who have SOP for 112, which provides a clearing mechanism for its working and a command centre in Lucknow.

States have to also establish grievance redressal systems for good Samaritans at district level, compliance of National Ambulance Code (NAC), paramedic training and accreditation, GPS in ambulances and different levels of trauma centres.

In its judgement, the Supreme Court has directed the chief secretaries for the compliance with the directions relating to the different departments within the states.

“Our opinion is that the government should enact a right to trauma care law, where they can include all these nine kinds of infrastructure which the supreme court has directed. The law will help in developing a comprehensive system and it provides for a nodal authority to implement it,” said Piyush Tewari of SaveLIFE Foundation, the petitioner in the case.

The Editorial Page

FRIDAY, JUNE 26, 2026

Silicon Valley to Seoul, watch AI exuberance

THE LAST few days have seen stock markets across the world wobble as concerns over the AI cycle weigh heavy on investors. On Tuesday, Asian markets fell sharply, led by South Korea's Kospi, which plunged by nearly 10 per cent. Japan's Nikkei 225 was down 3.5 per cent and Nasdaq, too, witnessed weakness, falling by almost 4 per cent since last week. Questions are increasingly being raised over monetisation of capital spending by tech firms and the high valuations they command. As per Goldman Sachs, the AI hyperscalers are expected to spend more than \$5 trillion on technology and data centres by 2030. Parallels are now being drawn with the dotcom bubble. Then, as now, investor exuberance had dramatically driven up share prices of tech firms. And when the bubble burst, it took Nasdaq years to fully recover.

Despite these concerns, capital has been flowing to companies linked to the AI cycle in all parts of the world. In Korea, for instance, SK Hynix and Samsung have seen euphoric investor interest. As per reports, the two now account for a sizeable share of the South Korean market. In Japan, companies like Advantest, Tokyo Electron and Kioxia have all seen their shares surge. In the US, AI behemoths — Anthropic and OpenAI — have begun the process to launch their initial public offerings. These will follow SpaceX's recent mega IPO, pulling in even more capital. Investor exuberance is, however, likely to run up against a macro reality. In the past, asset bubbles have tended to be pricked by central banks raising interest rates. And with inflation edging upwards in the US — CPI rose to 4.2 per cent in May — it raises the possibility of the Federal Reserve tightening policy in the months ahead.

Indian markets have not been part of this AI play. Foreign capital has, in fact, been exiting the country. In 2025, foreign portfolio investors took out \$18.9 billion from the stock markets, and so far this year, outflows have been just shy of \$30 billion. Alongside, net FDI flows dwindled to \$1 billion in 2024-25 and \$7.7 billion in 2025-26. Along with high crude prices, this put pressure on the rupee. In recent weeks, however, oil prices have softened considerably, and measures have been taken to boost capital flows and help stabilise the currency. But more needs to be done. Steps should be taken to improve the country's attractiveness as an investment destination, for both domestic and foreign investors.

Global South is becoming another India-China arena



ANUSHKA SAXENA

ON JUNE 22, NSA Ajit Doval met Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi on the sidelines of the 16th BRICS NSA meeting in New Delhi. The divergences in worldviews were hard to miss. Delhi spoke of “stable, predictable and constructive bilateral relations” and “gradual normalisation” since Galwan. Beijing, by contrast, scaled the same meeting up to a “Global South” moment: Wang declared that “the Global South, including China and India, is collectively rising”, and that the two countries must “accelerate the modernisation process of the Global South” together. Five days earlier, that exact vocabulary had been packaged into China's new White Paper on global governance.

The White Paper articulates three approaches to the Global South. First is its revitalisation of an idea that a Global South that excludes China is a pseudo-proposition. Second is its emphasis on China's “win-win” and “harmonious” approach to the perceived grouping. Third is its usurpation of Delhi's preferred metaphor on acting as a bridge between the “Global North” and the “Global South”. Only, the White Paper frames it as China seeking to “synergise” North-South cooperation.

China has viewed India and the West as promoters of exclusive blocs that undermine its Global South identity. The White Paper's most prominent thesis formalises that proposition — “China will always be a member of the Global South.” It contends that the monopolisation of international affairs by “a small number of countries” is no longer acceptable to Beijing, and so it will emerge as the force promoting inclusion and accessibility for the economies of this perceived grouping. India's decision to conduct three “Voice of Global South Summits” without China's participation has irked Beijing the most. It was right before the second summit that *Global Times* popularised the idea that such a summit without China was a pseudo-proposition.

Through the White Paper, Beijing attempts to set itself apart in its approach to the Global South by calling for “win-win cooperation,” pitting it against the West's, or even India's, “opportunism”. The example Chinese analysts like retired PLA officer Zhou Bo have cited is Delhi wrangling with Colombo to halt the docking of Chinese vessels at Sri Lanka's ports. Zhou argued in 2024 that while India “forced [Sri Lanka's] government to ban Chinese ships”, China welcomed it into BRICS and the SCO. In his conception, that India is an equal in BRICS, or that it acted in its national interest when dealing with Colombo, are unacceptable realities. Zhou also advanced the framing that India and China should function as “Global South anchors”, not power competitors. That has now travelled from a retired PLA officer's op-ed to Wang Yi's talking points. The precedent, however, as evident from Sri Lanka's debt restructuring around Hambantota or the suspension of the BRI-financed CPEC's signature projects under fiscal stress in Pakistan, does not reflect the conduct of the magnanimous actor that China presents itself as. Delhi's goal should hence be not to compete with Beijing's rhetoric word-for-word, but to showcase its empirical record in Global South fora.

The writer is staff research analyst, geostrategy programme, Takshashila Institution

That India and China should function as ‘Global South anchors’, not power competitors, has now travelled from a retired PLA officer's op-ed to Wang Yi's talking points

• LEGAL

‘100%’ tag on label, disclaimers on the back: Why CCPA fined 2 companies

Vineet Bhalla
New Delhi, June 25

FROM JUICES to breads, the “100%” label is a near-ubiquitous marketing tool meant to assure consumers of a product’s unadulterated quality.

In two orders this month, however, the Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) imposed a penalty of Rs 1 lakh each on two major food and beverage companies — Mrs. Bectors Food Specialities Ltd and Stora Foods and Beverages Pvt Ltd — for running misleading advertisements and engaging in unfair trade practices by prominently using “100%” claims on their packaging and promotional materials.

The CCPA invoked Section 2(28) of the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, which defines a “misleading advertisement” as one that falsely describes a product, gives a false guarantee or deliberately conceals important information. It also relied on Section 2(47), which defines an “unfair trade practice” as making false representations about the standard, quality or composition of goods. The regulatory backdrop for these orders was set by the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI). In an advisory in May last year, the food regulator noted a trend of brands using the “100%” term. The FSSAI had said the term is not defined in its advertising regulations and that its use “is likely to convey a false sense of absolute purity or superiority...”.

‘100% Atta Bread’

This false sense of purity was the focal point in the case against Mrs. Bectors, the makers of English Oven bread. The CCPA took suo motu cognisance of advertisements for the company’s “100% Atta Bread” and “100% Whole Wheat Bread”. The company admitted that the actual wheat flour (atta) content was only 87%. But it said the “100%” was meant to convey that wheat flour was the “sole grain source” used, without any refined flour (maida). The company also relied on FSSAI labelling regulations, which state that for a bread to be classified as “Whole Wheat Bread”, it must contain a minimum of 75% whole wheat flour. The CCPA, however, said that the

MERE TECHNICAL COMPLIANCE IS NOT ENOUGH

- Both companies attempted to use technical compliance with food safety standards as a defence against the application of Consumer Protection Act.
 - But the CCPA held that compliance with manufacturing rules does not offer a ‘safe harbour’ for deceptive advertising.
 - It said the enactment of the 2019 Act has shifted the principle of ‘buyer beware’ to ‘seller beware’.
- FSSAI regulations cannot be “elevated into a justification for making an unqualified and absolute claim such as ‘100% Atta Bread’.” It observed that a consumer would reasonably construe the label to mean the product is entirely composed of atta.

‘100% Tender Coconut Water’

The CCPA applied similar reasoning was applied in the case against Stora. In this, the CCPA investigated the company’s “100% Tender Coconut Water” and various “100% Juice” variants. The consumer watchdog found that Stora’s coconut water was reconstituted from a 9.6% coconut water concentrate. Likewise, its “100% Juice” variants consisted predominantly of water, with fruit pulp or concentrate ranging between 4% and 16%.

Stora contended that the FSSAI permits the reconstitution of juices from concentrates. The company said that because its manufacturing process was legally compliant and because it had included a disclaimer on the back of the pack stating the product was “reconstituted”, the front-of-pack “100%” claim was valid.

The CCPA, however, drew a distinction between a permitted manufacturing process and deceptive marketing. It ruled that while FSSAI allows reconstitution, it does not grant a manufacturer the right to present a diluted, reconstituted product as undiluted natural produce. The watchdog said fine-print disclaimers on the back of the pack don’t make up for misleading claims on the front.

• GLOBAL

Behind Venezuela’s quake devastation: Rare ‘seismic doublet’, vulnerable location

Anagha Jayakumar
New Delhi, June 25

THE TWIN earthquakes near Venezuela capital Caracas are feared to have killed tens of thousands. The first quake, with a magnitude of 7.2, hit about 160 km west of Caracas late on Wednesday night. Just 39 seconds later, it was followed by a magnitude 7.5 quake. The US Geological Survey (USGS) described the disaster as a “seismic doublet”. The second quake was the largest to strike Venezuela or just off its coast since 1900, according to the USGS.

The agency’s preliminary death toll estimate ranges from 10,000 to 100,000. Officials warned this could become one of the country’s deadliest natural disasters.

What do we know about the quakes?

The first earthquake struck about 24 km from San Felipe in Yaracuy state. The second hit near Morón in neighbouring Carabobo state, about 168 km west of Caracas, according to the USGS.

The shocks from the disaster were felt as far away as neighbouring Colombia, with residents in the capital, Bogotá, reporting

feeling the tremors. *Associated Press* also reported that buildings were evacuated in Manaus, Belem and Macapa in Brazil’s Amazon region. Venezuela President Delcy Rodríguez said the worst-affected areas included Caracas and the north-central states of Miranda, La Guaira, Aragua, Carabobo and Falcón. Despite the widespread damage, Venezuela’s oil infrastructure did not appear to be affected, according to *Reuters*.

Why was it called a doublet?

Given that both earthquakes occurred within a short time and distance from each other, the USGS classified the event as a doublet. In a typical sequence, the larger quake is followed by a series of smaller aftershocks. Doublets, however, are generally defined as earthquakes of similar magnitude that originate from distinct but closely related ruptures and occur in quick succession.

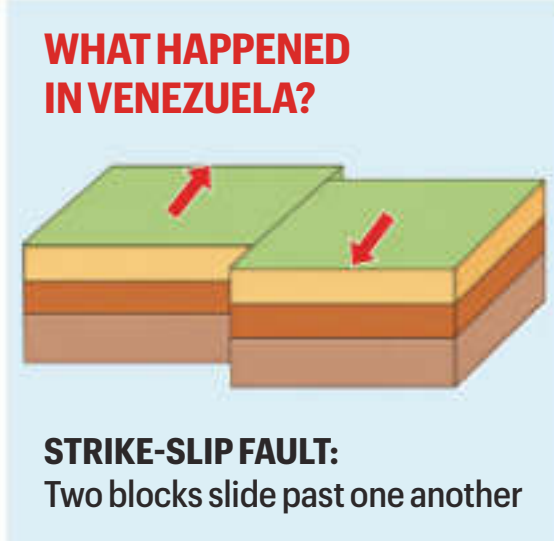
What caused the earthquakes?

Venezuela sits in one of the most seismically active regions in northern South America, along the boundary between the Caribbean and South American tectonic

• What is a fault?

A fault is a fracture or zone of fractures between two blocks of rock. When these blocks move rapidly, they cause quakes.

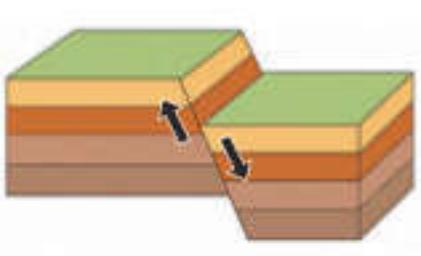
WHAT HAPPENED IN VENEZUELA?



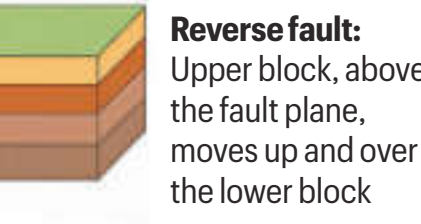
STRIKE-SLIP FAULT:
Two blocks slide past one another

Some other types of faults

Normal fault:
The block above the fault moves downward relative to the block below.



Reverse fault:
Upper block, above the fault plane, moves up and over the lower block



ness” that formed a seismic doublet. The USGS said quakes of this size should not be viewed as a single point on a map but as the rupture of a much larger section of fault.

Why were they so destructive?

The mainshock occurred at a relatively shallow depth of about 10 km. This meant that the shockwaves reached the surface with high intensity. Worsening the situation was the fact that this was a doublet, distinct from routine aftershocks.

“Aftershocks are largely a result of disturbances or ruptures caused by the main earthquake. Some stress is already present, and it is then amplified by the main earthquake, resulting in another quake. Aftershocks are usually one or more magnitude smaller than the main earthquake, although these are not very tight definitions, and have to be assessed on a case-by-case basis,” Vineet Gehlot, director of Dehradun-based Wadia Institute of Himalayan Geology, told *The Indian Express*.

“Doublets are two independent events happening within a very short span of time, a few seconds or a few minutes, or maybe a couple of hours. They are roughly of the

same magnitude and happen in close proximity to each other,” he said.

Doublets can also be especially destructive because they prolong the strong ground shaking. A 2016 study in *Nature Geoscience* analysing Pakistan’s 1997 Hamai earthquake found that a second major shock, which struck 19 seconds after the first, doubled both the duration of ground shaking and the area affected by the strongest shaking. Thus, buildings weakened by the first quake remain exposed to another major shock almost immediately, increasing the risk of collapse and complicating rescue efforts.

Have doublets occurred in the past?

- **IN 2023**, a doublet quake struck Turkey and Syria, measuring at magnitudes of 7.8 and 7.7. These happened just 95 km and nine hours apart, affecting 14 million people and causing widespread damage.
- **IN 2021**, a major doublet-like event occurred when quakes of magnitudes 8.6 and 8.2 struck the Indian Ocean, near Malaysia.
- **IN 1988**, a “triplet” — a series of three earthquakes just half an hour apart from each other — occurred in Australia.

- WITH INPUTS FROM AMITABH SINHA

• POLICY

If passport is not proof of citizenship, what is

DEEPTIMAN TIWARY

THE MINISTRY of External Affairs (MEA) Wednesday clarified that a passport is primarily a travel document and not a standalone proof of citizenship. The statement, made on Passport Seva Divas, triggered confusion. For most Indians, the passport is the most authoritative document issued by the state — carrying the Republic’s name, accepted across the world and issued only after verification by government authorities.

The MEA’s clarification, however, reflects a longstanding position: a passport is issued because the government is satisfied a person is an Indian citizen, but it does not create citizenship, nor is it conclusive proof of citizenship if challenged in law.

Citizenship a legal status

Articles 5 to 11 of the Constitution and the Citizenship Act, 1955 define who is an Indian citizen. Significantly, neither identifies any single document as proof of citizenship.

Instead, citizenship is treated as a legal status arising from facts such as birth, parentage, domicile, or naturalisation. Documents serve as evidence of those facts. For a person born in India, citizenship depends on when they were born and, in certain cases, the citizenship status of their parents. For someone naturalised, it depends on compliance with statutory conditions.

This distinction is reflected in an answer given by the Ministry of Home Affairs in Parliament in February 2020. Asked whether Aadhaar, passport, voter ID, PAN card or birth certificate constitute valid proof of citizenship, the government said: “Acquisition of Indian Citizenship is governed by The Citizenship Act, 1955 and rules made thereunder. Citizenship of India can be acquired by birth or descent or registration or naturalisation or incorporation of territory. The eligibility criteria for acquisition and determination of citizenship is as per the provisions of the Citizenship Act, 1955.”

Notably, it did not identify any of the documents as citizenship documents. Yet, under the Citizenship Rules, 2003, those seeking Indian citizenship under certain provisions produce a copy of their parents’

• WHO IS AN INDIAN CITIZEN?

Under the Citizenship Act of 1955, there are four ways to obtain citizenship:

- 1. Citizenship by birth:** For birthright citizenship, those born in India between 1950 and 1987 are citizens.
 - For those born between 1987 and 2003, citizenship is accorded only if either parent is a citizen of India at the time of their birth.
 - For those born after 2003, citizenship is accorded if only if either parent is a citizen at the time of their birth and the other is not an illegal immigrant.
- 2. Citizenship by descent:** A person born outside India and who has at least one Indian parent will be granted citizenship, provided that the birth is registered within one year with the Indian consulate in the jurisdiction.
- 3. Citizenship by registration:** This is for persons related to an Indian citizen through marriage or ancestry.

- Citizenship is treated as a legal status arising from facts such as birth, parentage, domicile or naturalisation.
- Documents serve as evidence of those facts. A **passport** is issued because the government is satisfied a person is a citizen. It does not create citizenship.

4. Citizenship by naturalisation:

Naturalisation certificate can be granted to a person who isn’t an illegal immigrant and has lived in India for 12 months continuously before applying.

- In the 14 years before the 12-month period, the person must have lived in India for at least 11 years. This is relaxed for some categories.

Waiver clause: If the Centre believes the applicant has rendered distinguished service to science, philosophy, art, literature, world peace or human progress, it may waive all or any of the conditions in the Act. This is how the Dalai Lama or Adnan Sami, the Pakistani singer, got Indian citizenship.

- BY APURVA VISHWANATH

passports to prove they are Indian citizens.

Eligibility for passport

Section 20 of the Act empowers the Centre to issue a passport or travel document even to non-Indian citizen if it considers such issuance necessary in public interest.

MEA sources said the provision is used in special cases. “Largely, cases where say an Indian origin person becomes stateless due to geo-political developments, or someone stateless is in India and must travel abroad,” an official said. Historically, Tibetan refugees and Sri Lankan Tamils in India have been issued special travel documents when visiting other countries, sources said. In 2023, the Madras High Court asked the Centre to grant a passport to a Sri Lankan Tamil Refugee under Section 20 of the Passport Act.

What courts have held

During hearings on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Bihar last year, a Supreme Court bench of Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi observed: “We would like you to clarify...we have repeatedly passed order that the list illustratively indicates 11 documents...if you see those 11, apart from passport and birth certificates, none are conclusive proof of citizenship.”

The observation appeared to place pas-

Common principle

In the UK and US, too, passports are issued because the state has determined that a person is a citizen; they do not themselves create citizenship.

-

The difference is that both countries have more robust civil registration systems and, for naturalised citizens, formal citizenship certificates.

epaper.indianexpress.com

New Delhi

FPI INVESTMENT IN FULLY ACCESSIBLE ROUTE BONDS HAS BEEN \$2.2 BILLION IN JUNE

Govt, RBI's bond measures pull 8 months of FPI money in 2 weeks

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, June 25

THE MEASURES announced by the government and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on June 5 to attract foreign capital into Indian sovereign bonds have started to work as hoped — debt falling under the Fully Accessible Route (FAR) category has seen inflows to the tune of \$2 billion in the subsequent two weeks, almost equal to the money that had come in the previous eight months combined.

Data from the National Securities Depository Ltd (NSDL) showed that Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have net bought FAR bonds on all but one day since capital gain taxes on government bonds have been done away with and the pool of securities in this category expanded. This has led to net inflows in these bonds in June rising to \$2.2 billion — the highest in 15 months.

In March 2025, FPIs had invested \$3.34 billion in FAR bonds — a category of government bonds that foreigners can invest in without any curbs.

According to Radhika Rao, Senior Economist at DBS Bank, foreign investors have “turned constructive” on rupee debt. “Sentiment has been supported

in part by expectations that Indian government bonds could be considered for inclusion in Bloomberg’s global bond indices,” Rao said Wednesday.

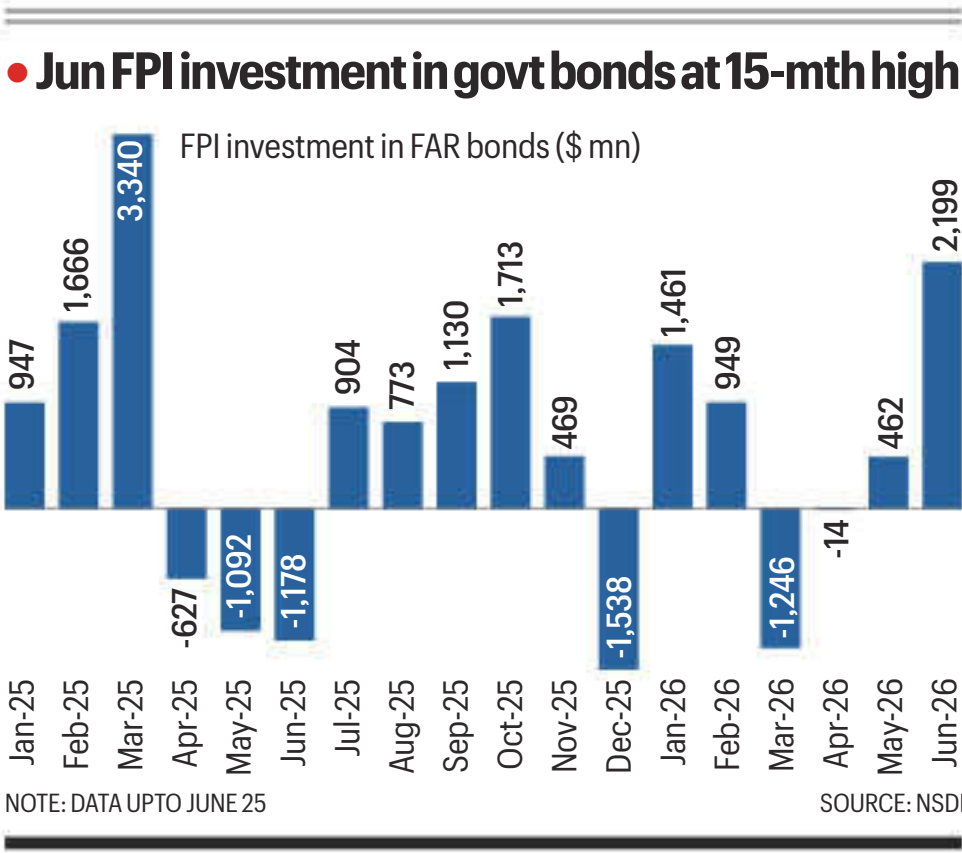
Cooling bond yields, triggers ahead

The removal of long- and short-term capital gains as well as the withholding tax on investment by foreign investors in government bonds was aimed at spurring their inclusion in the Bloomberg Global Aggregate Bond Index, which economists predict could pull in anywhere between \$20 billion to \$30 billion of passive foreign funds over a period of 10 months post inclusion.

Several global funds track the weight a certain country has in these bond indices and invest accordingly.

In January, Bloomberg Index Services Ltd (BISL) had deferred the inclusion of Indian government bonds into its flagship global index, saying it will provide another update by mid-2026. Over the last couple of years, Indian government debt has been added to bond indices of JPMorgan, Bloomberg’s Emerging Market Local Currency Index and that of FTSE Russell.

On Thursday, yield on the benchmark 10-year Indian gov-



ernment bond was 6.77% in secondary market, 22 basis points (bps) lower than on June 4.

One basis point is one-hundredth of a percentage point. Bond yields move opposite to their prices. So, a fall in yields means prices have risen, which is profitable for bond holders.

The decline in bond yields has also been aided by comments by RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra, who in an interview this week argued against expectations of interest rate hikes.

While foreign investors are now putting more money into

government bonds, they continue to dump stock, with net share sales increasing to \$5.55 billion so far this month from \$3.45 billion in May.

Consequently, net FPI investment in Indian shares and debt across all categories has still seen an outflow of \$562 million so far in June, as per NSDL data. As a result, the Indian rupee is trading not too far from its June 5 level of 94.94 per dollar, having closed at 94.40 on Thursday.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

RBI's G-sec holding rises to 13-year high

Christina Titus & Kishor Kadam
Mumbai, June 25

THE RBI's holdings of Indian government securities rose to a multi-year high after aggressive bond purchases. As per the data it released this week, RBI's bond holdings rose to 17.6% of outstanding issuance at the end of March from 14.5% as of December-end.

“The RBI had to undertake large-scale G-Sec purchases through OMO operations to inject durable liquidity into the banking system, which resulted in RBI holdings reaching multi-year highs,” said Mataprasad Pandey, VP, Arete Capital. It had bought bonds worth Rs 3.5 lakh crore via open market operations and Rs 90,000 crore through secondary market purchases in March quarter. In FY26, they purchased a record Rs 8.56 lakh crore, accounting for over 80% of net borrowing. As of March-end, outstanding bond issuance was at Rs 125.67 lakh crore. FE

RBI'S NEW FRAUD COMPENSATION MECHANISM

Relief to digital fraud victims: How losses up to Rs 50K can be recovered

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 25

VICTIMS OF digital transaction fraud can breathe easy. Under the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) revised compensation mechanism, victims of digital payment fraud involving amounts up to Rs 50,000 can recover a major portion of the money lost to fraud. Notified by the central bank on Wednesday, and effective January 1, 2027, the new system is another measure to limit customer liability and safeguard customers in such situations.

The new framework, under which the RBI has offered to compensate a substantial portion, comes at a time when bank frauds, especially digital transaction frauds, have become a growing concern for it. In FY26, while the reported fraud cases more than halved to 10,114, the amount involved rose 46% to Rs 48,021 crore.

What has changed?

The central bank has attempted to make the new compensation guidelines strongly pro-consumer. The RBI will contribute the major part of the compensation under the new framework.

Under the new mechanism, victims are eligible for compensation of up to 85% of their losses, up to Rs 25,000, thereby reducing the hit they take from such frauds. A bona fide victim who lodged a complaint involving gross loss of an amount up to Rs 50,000 on account of a fraudulent electronic banking transaction (EBT) will be compensated 85% of the net loss amount or Rs 25,000, whichever is less, once during the lifetime, the RBI's new framework reads. For a complaint involving a loss of less than Rs 29,412 via fraudulent EBT, the customer will re-



New framework comes as digital transaction frauds have become a key concern for RBI. REUTERS

ceive 85% of the amount as compensation. Victims are eligible for such compensation only if they lodge a complaint regarding the fraud within five calendar days. The loss must also be established in accordance with the internal processes set out in the victim's bank's policy.

Who pays the compensation?

The RBI states that victim's bank must compensate them entirely for any fraud arising from the bank's negligence. Negligence in this case includes failing to ensure proper safety and security mechanisms for EBTs,

failing to send mandatory alerts for EBTs above Rs 500, failing to provide 24x7 channels for customer complaints, system malfunctions, security breaches, and failing to act diligently on customer complaints. The framework specifies that banks must resolve customer complaints regarding fraudulent EBTs within 45 calendar days for domestic fraudulent EBTs, and within 60 days for cross-border fraudulent EBTs. In the case of a fraud of less than Rs 29,412, where the customer is to be paid 85% of the amount lost in compensation, 65% of the cost

DAY AFTER NEGOTIATIONS ENDED IN DELHI

For a trade deal, US has to ensure competitive edge for India: Goyal

'US has to find appropriate tools, legal backing for it'

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 25

A DAY after a visiting US delegation, led by United States Trade Representative (USTR) Jamieson Greer, concluded negotiations on a bilateral trade deal with India, Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said Thursday that the agreement will be signed the day the US ensures a competitive edge for India over countries such as Vietnam, Thailand, the Philippines, Indonesia, Malaysia and China.

Responding to a question on the status of the deal at the India Global Forum in London, Goyal said, “The India-US deal was done on February 6th. It was confirmed by both the US and India. There were International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariffs when we finalised the trade deal. We had negotiated the deal based on bringing down the 50% (tariff) to 18%. The whole deal was centred around that competitive advantage that we got with 18% over our neighbours and competing countries... lower than ASEAN countries other than Singapore.”

“With the US Supreme Court striking down the IEEPA tariffs,



Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal during the India Global Forum (IGF) UK-India Week, in London, on Thursday. PTI

and now with the 10%, which expires on July 24, we have to have some reason to be able to enter into force that agreement which we have agreed upon,” he said.

“And until the framework of getting into the competitive advantage can be finalised, we cannot enter into a US deal. That is broadly the discussion on how the US will find the appropriate tools and legal backing to give us the competitive advantage over our competition. The day this happens, the deal is on,” Goyal said.

Meanwhile, the EU Thursday became one of the largest trading partners to enforce the US deal after the US Supreme Court in February this year ruled tariffs under the IEEPA illegal. Several US deals automatically became unenforceable by partner countries as reciprocal tariffs were no longer in effect.

The US is working on a new tariff structure under Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974.

Under the US-EU deal, the EU is expected to eliminate tariffs on all US industrial goods and to provide preferential market access for a wide range of American seafood and agricultural goods including tree nuts, dairy products, fresh and processed fruits and vegetables, processed foods, planting seeds, soybean oil, and pork and bison meat.

The US, in turn, committed to apply the higher of either the US Most Favoured Nation (MFN) tariff rate or a tariff rate of 15%, comprising the MFN tariff and a reciprocal tariff, on originating goods of the EU.

But on June 18, the US opened a fresh Section 301 investigation on Germany, the EU's largest economy.

FIRST QUAKE of magnitude 7.2 hit west of Moron on Caribbean coast; a minute later, a second 7.5 magnitude earthquake struck.

DISTRAUGHT RESIDENTS search for their loved ones in the rubble; shocked survivors taken away on stretchers.

VENEZUELA HAS been facing economic disarray and this disaster poses a huge challenge for President Delcy Rodríguez.

‘Like a horror movie scene’

Collapsed homes & lives: Quakes in Venezuela one of worst in its history

Associated Press & Reuters
Caracas, June 25

VENEZUELAN SEARCHED for survivors beneath collapsed buildings on Thursday and rescue teams raced to the areas hardest hit by a pair of powerful earthquakes that rocked northern Venezuela, killing at least 164 people. The 7.2- and 7.5-magnitude earthquakes that struck Wednesday evening were among the strongest in Venezuela in more than a century and could be felt throughout region.

Buildings were evacuated as far away as Brazil's Amazon, about 1,700 km from Caracas, where the country's main airport was closed after sustaining damages. Panicked residents of poured into the streets, where many people walked among the debris searching for the missing. Television broadcasts showed rescue workers using power tools to get through piles of rubble where buildings stood.

In La Guaira, Cristian Carreño stared stunned at his charred apartment building tilting precariously to one side. "I lost everything. Everything," he said. "There are people still inside, I imagine, that couldn't get out. It's incredibly devastating."

The natural disaster poses a major challenge for acting President Delcy Rodríguez, the former vice president who took office in January after the capture of Maduro. Venezuela has been facing economic disarray for more than a decade, and many people reject the legitimacy of the political movement she represents. Footage on state TV showed three children, covered in dust but alive, pulled from the rubble in La Guaira state, which Rodríguez described as a "disaster zone."

"When we went downstairs, the scene was like a horror

"It was awful. We cried, we screamed. Thankfully, we're alive."

MARÍA CRISTINA DÍAZ,
A JANITOR

movie," María Alejandra, a resident, told *Reuters*.

Rodríguez appealed to businesses to make heavy construction equipment available for rescue operations, adding search and rescue teams certified by the UN were on their way to help.

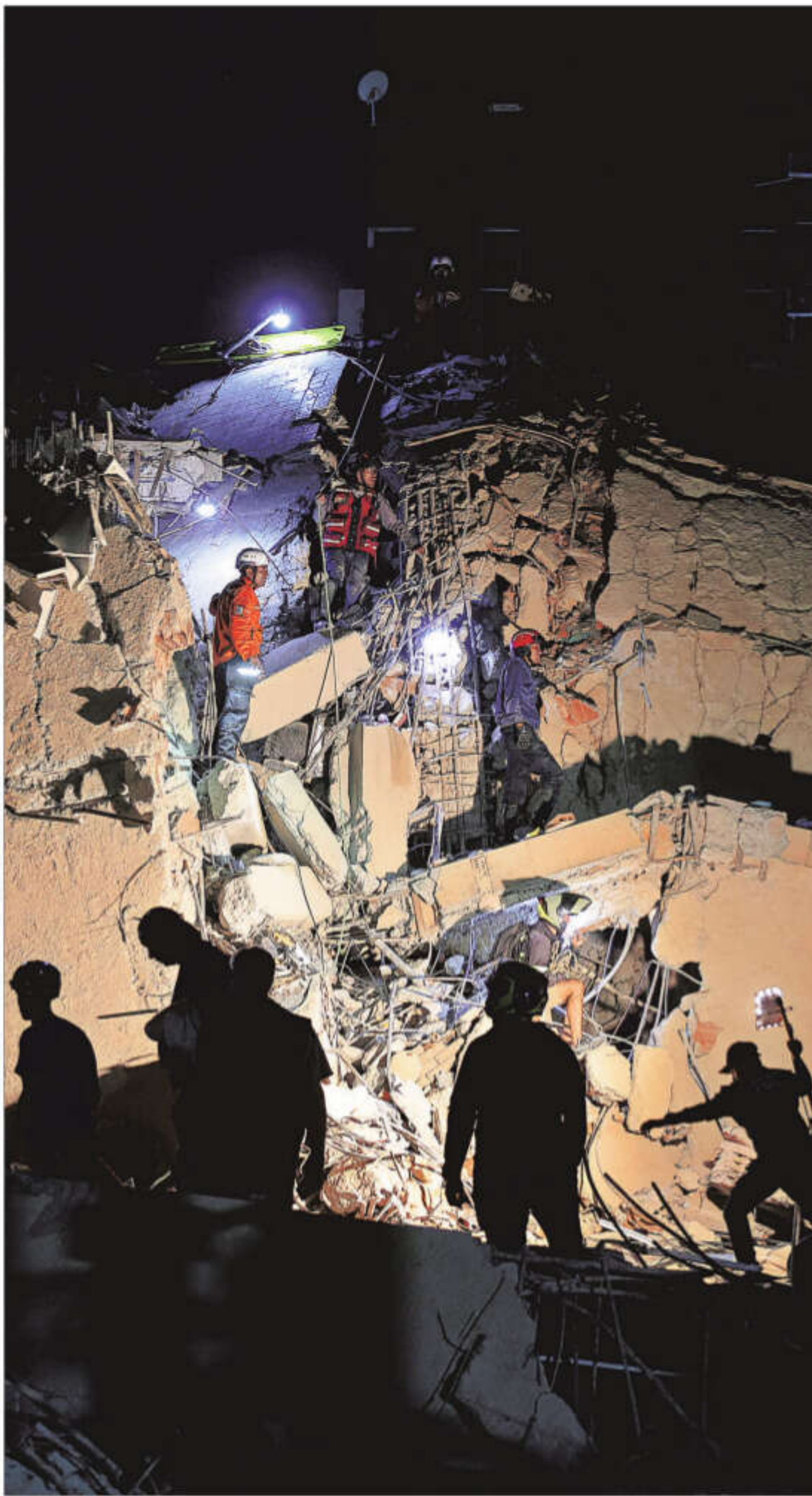
The US Geological Survey said the first earthquake, with a magnitude of 7.2, hit west of Moron on the Caribbean coast, about 170 km west of Caracas. It had a depth of 22 km. Just a minute later, USGS reported a second 7.5 magnitude quake, with a depth of 10 km and an epicenter 16 km southwest of Moron.

During the quakes, people ran from swaying buildings, and many were shocked when they turned back to see destroyed walls that left furniture visible from the street.

Dayana Delgado, mother of three children, said she was desperate because her 8-year-old was missing. "I want to know where my child is, if he's trapped or in a shelter," she said.

In downtown Caracas, hundreds of people spent the night huddled around parks, parking lots and open spaces. "We were afraid the buildings would collapse on us," said María Cristina Díaz, a 41-year-old janitor. "My mother, my daughter and I were cold. We didn't sleep a wink; but I didn't want to spend the night alone at home after that terrible earthquake."

"It was awful. We cried, we screamed. Thankfully, we're alive," she added.



Rescue workers search through the rubble after an earthquake in Caracas, Venezuela, on Thursday. AP

Trump says earthquakes caused a 'devastating number of deaths'

Reuters

Washington, June 25

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Wednesday said the two earthquakes that hit Venezuela earlier in the day had "left a devastating number of deaths," without citing any official casualty figures.

"The two major earthquakes that just hit the great people of Venezuela are both massive in scale and have left a devastating number of deaths," Trump said in a post on Truth Social. "The USA stands ready, willing, and able to help! I have instructed all agencies of our government to get ready to move quickly. We will be there for our new and great friends. Early reports are not good."

The US said late on Wednesday it was in touch with Venezuelan authorities and was mobilizing assistance for the South American nation. "We're in touch with the authorities and mobilizing assistance," Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau said on X. He said the earthquakes were "devastating."

US State Department official Jeremy Lewin said on X the department mobilized a disaster

• WORLD OFFERS HELP

"We pray for the speedy recovery of those injured and stand in solidarity with all those affected during this difficult time. India stands ready to extend all possible assistance."

NARENDRA MODI, PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA



"The USA stands ready, willing and able to help! I have instructed all agencies of our government to get ready to move quickly. We will be there for our new and great friends."

DONALD TRUMP, PRESIDENT OF UNITED STATES

"France stands ready... to provide assistance to the affected Venezuelan population... A team of 85 French rescue workers specializing in search and rescue operations is being deployed immediately."

EMMANUEL MACRON, PRESIDENT OF FRANCE



assistance team and task force to deliver and coordinate critical assistance to Venezuelans.

"Working with our partners in the interim Venezuelan government, the US will be sending search and rescue teams, medi-

cal and humanitarian supplies and other resources in the crucial first days after this tragic natural disaster," he added.

The US Embassy in Caracas reported that all American personnel were accounted for.



Residents console a man outside his home after successive earthquakes, in Caracas, on Thursday. AP

As Hormuz oil flow rebounds, US tries to reassure Gulf allies that deal is sound

Trump clashes with Republican senator over Iran agreement

Reuters

Dubai, Washington, June 25

OIL PRICES fell to pre-war levels on Thursday as the United States said flows through the Strait of Hormuz were nearing normal and its top diplomat wrapped up a Gulf tour aimed at winning support for a preliminary Iran deal.

US Energy Secretary Chris Wright said shipments through the strait were approaching levels seen before the US and Israel launched strikes on Iran on February 28, with at least 20 mil-

Cargo ship 'attacked' while crossing Strait of Hormuz

London, Athens: A cargo ship reported a suspected attack as it attempted to pass through the Strait of Hormuz close to the coast of Oman on Thursday, British navy agency UKMTO said.

The UN's International Maritime Organization is currently assisting ships escape the Gulf, hundreds of which have been stranded there since the Iran war

began at the end of February.

The ship reported being struck on its starboard side by a projectile 7.5 nautical miles southeast of Oman's port of Dahit, the UKMTO said.

Another maritime security source said the vessel was likely targeted by a drone, although it was not clear yet who carried out the strike.

REUTERS

lion barrels exiting the strait in the previous 24 hours.

Despite the recovery in traffic, Iran signaled it would continue to assert control. Its Revolutionary Guards on Thursday

warned vessels to stick to routes through the strait designated by Tehran, rejecting newly announced shipping routes not coordinated with Iran as unacceptable and dangerous.

The warning came after Oman announced temporary shipping lanes through the strait in coordination with the United Nations' shipping agency.

Data from the UN's International Maritime Organization showed that 57 ships carrying about 1,100 seafarers have transited the strait since June 23 under the evacuation plan.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio sought to reassure Gulf allies wary of Washington's preliminary accord with Tehran.

After meeting with Gulf Arab foreign ministers in Bahrain, home to the US Navy's Fifth Fleet, he told reporters that Gulf allies shared some serious concerns and that they wanted to be informed of every step of the peace accord, which includes provisions on Strait of Hormuz.

• PLASTIC SURGERY CLINICS, UPSCALE RESTAURANTS AND BOUTIQUE FITNESS STUDIOS HAVE SPRUNG UP TO SERVE TECH WORKERS FLUSH WITH A.I. RICHES

From rice fields to silicon riches: How Hsinchu became heart of Taiwan's chip boom

Amy Chang Chien & Meaghan Tobin

Hsinchu (Taiwan), June 25

LO REMEMBERS when the most coveted real estate in Taiwan was farmland.

When she moved to the area 16 years ago, there were no department stores, office parks or fine-dining restaurants. "It was very desolate," she said.

Today, nothing could be further from the truth. The rice fields have given way to Hsinchu, home to Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co. and ground zero for an industry

driving the global economy: the production of the advanced computer chips powering the artificial intelligence boom.

As Taiwan's semiconductor industry took off, TSMC made chips that drive virtually every kind of electronic device. That includes the sought-after AI accelerators designed by Nvidia, the world's most valuable company. Farmers were gradually priced out of the area by factories, offices and luxury high-rises. The high-speed rail linking Taiwan's largest cities now carries 80 million people a year through Lo's backyard.

In northern Hsinchu, an area known as Zhubei, real estate prices have skyrocketed as buyers compete for spots on yearlong waiting lists for new apartments near Hsinchu Science Park, where TSMC has headquarters. Plastic surgery clinics, upscale restaurants and boutique fitness studios have sprung up to serve tech workers flush with AI riches.

Over the past six years, households near Hsinchu Science Park have reported some of the highest incomes in Taiwan. In one neighbourhood, average household incomes ex-



The Big City mall is a temple catering to Hsinchu's nouveau riche, with a Tesla showroom on the first floor. NYT

ceeded \$146,000 in 2023, about five times Taiwan's average.

The prosperity has given rise to the so-called Zhuke Mama: a woman whose husband works in the lucrative semiconductor industry, allowing her time for pursuits like going to Pilates classes, shopping for vacation homes in Thailand and managing their children's academic advancement.

While the rest of Taiwan and much of East Asia are grappling with a sharp population decline, so many children have been born in Hsinchu in recent years that the schools cannot

keep up. Public high schools in the area now admit only students with sufficiently high test scores, a practice that Lo and a group of mothers have protested. Those who do not make the cut must commute to another school district.

"The population exploded," Lo said. "It became very competitive."

Today, Hsinchu is home to more than 1 million people, and those without ties to the technology industry have largely been priced out. The wealth generated by semiconductors has not translated to wage gains

in other industries.

The local shopping mall, Big City, now ranks among Taiwan's top-performing retail centers.

During its big sale in December, it generated more than \$100 million in just 12 days, a 6% increase from the year before, according to Alex Ro, a general manager.

The mall is a temple catering to Hsinchu's nouveau riche, with a Tesla showroom on the first floor, feet away from an Apple Store. At Brooks Brothers, some suits cost nearly \$1,500 — more than the monthly salary of most retail workers. NYT

